



chaabi

The WhatsApp-Based Learning Platform

Case Study

This case was written by **J. Shalom Jenifer** and reviewed by **K. Bhagyalakshmi**, Amity Research Centers Headquarter, Bangalore. It is intended to be used as the basis for class discussion rather than to illustrate either effective or ineffective handling of a management situation. The case was compiled from published sources.

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“chaabi is solving one of the biggest problems that India faces, which is the upskilling of its blue-collar workforce. The idea is to help our blue-collar workforce be better at their jobs, future-ready, and more productive for the overall economy.”

“We streamline the process by taking entire standard operating procedures (SOPs) or documentation, such as HR or training materials, from a company. For AI systems, our goal is to construct training in the language of the blue-collar worker, ensuring accuracy and relevance to their roles and specific tasks.”

– Puneet Dhiman, Founder & CEO, chaabi

The rising demand for proficient blue-collar workers in India was driven by the swift expansion of sectors like manufacturing, logistics, and delivery services. However, the existing training system was not equipped to meet the growing demand for a diverse country like India where language barriers and educational limitations added further challenges. Insufficient access to comprehensive skill development, particularly in ‘soft skills and communication’, was a major challenge for blue-collar workers. Lack of training in these essential areas had put many blue-collar workers such as ‘cab drivers, factory workers, and service industries’ at a disadvantage.

The skill gap led to challenges in customer interactions, decreased job efficiency, and limited opportunities for career growth. Additionally, conventional training methods often failed to cater to the specific needs and constraints of blue-collar workers, due to limited time and resources for education. It emphasised the urgent requirement for ‘innovative, accessible, and scalable training programs’. These initiatives effectively narrowed the skill gap for millions of workers, empowered them to enhance their career opportunities and contribute effectively to their industries. Market research stated 73% increase in job vacancies were targeted at blue-collar and grey-collar workers. It indicated the growing need for qualified workers in various industries. A survey reported, 92% of workers had no vocational training, while 87% of workers struggled to learn in English and in Hindi. This led to the development of chaabi, an AI-Powered WhatsApp-based learning program.

In 2022, chaabi.ai (chaabi) was founded by Puneet Dhiman (Dhiman) in Gurugram (**Exhibit I**). Dhiman started his career with Technorite Consultants as a software engineer. Dhiman progressed in his career as Senior Strategic Account Manager at Google. Before launching chaabi, he started Culturebay, an online platform that featured handcrafted products of India. Dhiman said, “I started my first company, CultureBy.com, which focused on Indian handmade

products. This is my second venture, almost after eight years of experience. I believe that working in startups allows you to grow faster, learn faster, and drive real change.”

Exhibit I

Puneet Dhiman - Founder of chaabi



Source: “With WhatsApp-based learning, This startup aims to upskill 1 million blue-collar workers by 2026”, <https://indianstartupnews.com/stories/this-b2b-saas-startup-is-utilising-whatsapp-to-upskill-1-million-blue-collar-workers-by-2026-2321205>, December 25th 2023

The COVID-19 pandemic and the ensuing crisis with migrant workers drove Dhiman to seek avenues to raise the level of expertise among India’s blue-collar workers. Dhiman said, “I aimed to tackle this challenge by using WhatsApp, a platform they use every day.” He added, “India’s 500 million plus blue-collar workforce is poised for transformation. With WhatsApp, India’s most widely used app, as the primary platform we ensure efficient delivery of job-specific training tailored to blue-collar workers. This approach helps in enhancing productivity and employability among this vital segment of our workforce.” chaabi aimed to improve the abilities of about 450 million blue-collar workers to a great extent in India.

chaabi was created as a B2B SaaS¹ platform to improvise the skillset of India’s blue-collar industry. The platform provided AI powered vernacular learning in more than 20 languages such as ‘Tamil, Telugu, Marathi, Bengali, and Kannada’ through WhatsApp. Employees with different linguistic backgrounds were trained in their mother tongues, which improved the effectiveness and inclusivity of the learning process.

The company aimed to offer blue-collar workers with practical solution for skill development by focusing on areas necessary to their career advancement and flexibility in the workplace. Dhiman stated, “WhatsApp is widely used among blue-collar workers. It allows us to deliver content in vernacular languages, making learning more accessible. WhatsApp’s simple and familiar interface enables seamless learning through videos, quizzes and self-assessments.” He added, “In our custom model, any worker in a company can record a few sentences in their voice. This allows us to use their voice for delivering the entire training content in many vernacular languages, offering a personalised experience.” It facilitated employees in adopting a personalised approach, thereby enhancing the learning process.

chaabi encouraged employees with a gamified approach to make learning quicker, enjoyable, participatory and to complete modules more quickly. Practical use for chaabi was to streamline business procedures. It could also convert ‘company’s standard operating procedures (SOPs) or HR and training materials’ into training modules in the preferred language by an employee. Dhiman said, “We streamline the process by taking entire standard operating procedures (SOPs) or documentation, such as HR or training materials, from a company. For AI systems,

¹ A SaaS model allowed business to remotely access data from any networked device.

our goal is to construct training in the language of the blue-collar worker, ensuring accuracy and relevance to their roles and specific tasks.” The company used monthly subscription model, with pricing based on an array of variables like user activity, workflow, and size of the company. chaabi also offered real-time data for businesses to monitor the number of users enrolled, the proportion of users who had completed training, and the advancement of users’ training. Tata Croma, Blinkit and Bluesmart were some of its clients.

New social media sites like ApnaApna and Zippia also helped blue-collar workers find jobs, develop their skills, and receive the appropriate training. chaabi’s goal was to, upskill one million individuals by 2026. Dhiman stated, “When it comes to what we teach, we’re focusing on two things. First, we’re putting together all the government-mandated regulatory and compliance training for blue-collar workers. Secondly, we’re emphasising essential soft skills such as punctuality and understanding office protocols. Instead of getting into complicated training, we’re starting with simple skills that make a big difference.” chaabi was a bootstrapped business that encountered challenges in effectively controlling expenses and striving to accelerate the pace of its development efforts.

chaabi’s strategy, helped to reduce the skill gap and empowered ‘employers, recruiters and government agencies’ to provide more specialised training. Dhiman believed ‘regardless of educational background, everyone could succeed if they had the right set of skills’. He added, “I recognised the necessity of two key elements: the right technology and the right content. It became evident that solving this challenge requires the marriage of both, as relying on just one wouldn’t suffice.”

The company completed a project with Blinkit on compliance training which included ‘code of conduct, POSH (Prevention of Sexual Harassment), employee health and safety, fire safety, and sustainability training’. The other players offering advice to employers on POSH compliance for blue-collar workers were SamānaCentre, Complykaro, and Rainmaker. chaabi was conferring with several government departments to determine the most appropriate model and initial areas that had to be focused. “Our primary focus is on the logistics and the delivery workforce, considering it’s a substantial sector for us. They often seek a user-friendly and efficient platform for soft skills training. We are also looking to expand into the manufacturing industry,” said Dhiman. chaabi’s goal was to, upskill one million individuals ensuing effective training program by 2026. Would chaabi play a pivotal role in shaping the future of vocational training for blue-collar workers in India?

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